

Vafa Behnam

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Department of Economics
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Placement Director: Prashant Bharadwaj
Placement Assistant: Andrew Flores

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Education

University of California, San Diego

2021–2027 (expected)

Ph.D. in Economics

Brown University

2016–2020

B.A. in Mathematics-Economics

B.A. in Computer Science

Fields

Primary: Trade, Development

Secondary: Macroeconomics, Economic History

References

Professor Sam Bazzi (*Co-Chair*)
sbazzi@ucsd.edu

Professor Fabian Eckert (*Co-Chair*)
fpe@ucsd.edu

Professor Munseob Lee
munseoble@ucsd.edu

Professor Fabian Trottner
ftrottner@ucsd.edu

Job Market Paper

When Does Trade Protection Help? Evidence from the Rise of American Manufacturing

When does trade protection boost growth and when does it harm growth? I study this question in the context of US industrialization in the 19th century. I develop an empirical design leveraging county-product variation in exposure to nationwide tariffs based on distance to international ports, using newly digitized tariff, import price and railway freight data. Exploiting a nationwide fiscal shock that suddenly raised tariffs for reasons unrelated to local industry conditions, I find protection reduces output growth for products close to the technological frontier but increases growth for products far from it. Protection also shifts patent activity towards far-from-frontier products, suggesting a reshaping of comparative advantage. I present a model of trade and innovation with variable markups generating these empirical results: for close-to-frontier products, protection substitutes for innovation as a source of market power; for far-from-frontier products, protection instead makes the market contestable enough that the domestic producer can capture the rents from innovation. This model provides an imperfect-competition rationale for infant industry protection distinct from the usual learning-by-doing justification. I conclude by studying the welfare effects of protection, which can be positive or negative in contrast to workhorse trade models.

Working Papers

Did 2018 Tariffs Boost Manufacturing Growth? A Local Industry Approach

What were the impacts of the 2018 Trump tariff hike on manufacturing growth? Motivated by gravity theory, I develop an empirical strategy that exploits cross-state variation in pre-treatment sectoral import volumes, which generates differential exposure to nationwide tariff increases. I find a \$1 tariff-induced reduction in imports raises output by \$0.63 at the state-sector level. Accounting for a number of spatial

spillover and general equilibrium channels, I estimate an implied nationwide manufacturing output gain from import protection of \$69.5 to \$127.5 billion. However, I find a \$1 retaliation-induced reduction in exports results in a \$3.4 loss in output, roughly five times the per-dollar output gain from import protection. A back-of-the-envelope calculation implies an aggregate loss of \$177.8 billion, suggesting export losses are larger than the gains from import protection.

Teaching Experience

As Head Instructor

University of California, San Diego

Principles of Macroeconomics

Summer 2025

Rated 4.33/5.0 in student evaluations

As Teaching Assistant

Brown University

Machine Learning (Computer Science)

Spring 2019

University of California, San Diego (*Economics unless noted*)

Short Run Macroeconomics

Fall 2024

Microeconomics B

Fall 2022, Summer 2024

Operations Research

Spring 2024

Decision Making Under Uncertainty

Winter 2024

Econometrics C

Fall 2023

Industrial Organization

Spring 2023, Summer 2023

Econometrics A

Winter 2023, Summer 2023

Microeconomics A

Winter 2022

Business Analytics Capstone (Rady School of Management)

Spring 2026

Applied Urban Economics for Planning and Development (Urban Studies and Planning)

Fall 2025, Winter 2026

Introduction to the Real Estate and Development Process (Urban Studies and Planning)

Summer 2024

Honors, Fellowships, and Grants

Best Graduate Student Paper, Empirical Investigations in International Trade (EIIT) Conference

2026

Teaching Assistant Excellence Award, UC San Diego

2024

Advancement to Candidacy Fellowship, UC San Diego

2024

Graduate Research Fellowship, UC San Diego

2022, 2023

Regents Fellowship, UC San Diego

2021

Undergraduate Teaching and Research Award, Brown University

2017

Employment

National Bureau of Economic Research, Full Time Research Assistant
– Cambridge, MA

May 2020 – Aug 2021

Blue Cross and Blue Shield of Rhode Island, Data Analyst –
Providence, RI

June 2018 – Sep 2018